12. The Land I Will Show You

Passage: Genesis 12:1–9 (the passage, with notes on the Hebrew)

Last week ended on one word: *Go*. Today Abram goes. In nine verses he walks more than four hundred miles, builds two altars, pitches a tent — and never says a word.

One thread runs through the whole passage, and it starts in the first sentence. God tells Abram exactly what to leave — *your country, your relatives, your father's household* — and almost nothing about where he is going: *"to the land that I will show you."* Then he doesn't show him. Not yet. Today we follow that thread, and ask what it means for people like us, who also have to start down roads before we can see where they go.

> ***1*** *Now the LORD said to Abram, "Go out from your country, your relatives, and your father's household to the land that I will show you.* ***2*** *Then I will make you into a great nation, and I will bless you, and I will make your name great, so that you will exemplify divine blessing.* ***3*** *I will bless those who bless you, but the one who treats you lightly I must curse, so that all the families of the earth may receive blessing through you."*
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> ***4*** *So Abram left, just as the LORD had told him to do, and Lot went with him. (Now Abram was 75 years old when he departed from Haran.)* ***5*** *And Abram took his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, and all the possessions they had accumulated and the people they had acquired in Haran, and they left for the land of Canaan. They entered the land of Canaan.* ***6*** *Abram traveled through the land as far as the oak tree of Moreh at Shechem. (At that time the Canaanites were in the land.)* ***7*** *The LORD appeared to Abram and said, "To your descendants I will give this land." So Abram built an altar there to the LORD, who had appeared to him.* ***8*** *Then he moved from there to the hill country east of Bethel and pitched his tent, with Bethel on the west and Ai on the east. There he built an altar to the LORD and worshiped the LORD.* ***9*** *Abram continually journeyed by stages down to the Negev.*

1. A stop in Haran (11:31)

The call does not come out of a clear sky. Read the verse just before it:

> *Terah took his son Abram, his grandson Lot… and his daughter-in-law Sarai… and with them he set out from Ur of the Chaldeans to go to Canaan. When they came to Haran, they settled there. (11:31)*

The family was already on the road to Canaan, with Terah in the lead, and it stopped. *They settled there* is word for word what the builders did at Babel (11:2). Haran — its name means "road" — was an easy place to stop: a rich city on the trade route, some six hundred miles up the Euphrates from Ur, and like Ur a city of the moon god (compare Joshua 24:2). They had moved. They had not yet left.

Where did God first speak? Genesis tells it here, in Haran. Stephen says God had already spoken in Mesopotamia, *"before he settled in Haran"* (Acts 7:2; compare Genesis 15:7) — which is why some Bibles translate 12:1 *"the LORD* ***had*** *said."* (Stephen also has Abram leave *"after his father died"* [7:4], which Genesis's numbers do not easily allow.) Either way, the story is more ordinary than the lightning bolt we often picture. The family set out, stayed in Haran long enough to grow rich (12:5), and there the word came: *Go.*

Jewish storytellers imagined that stop. In *Jubilees*, written about two centuries before Christ, Abram sits up one night in Haran watching the stars, and prays:

> *Shall I return unto Ur of the Chaldees who seek my face that I may return to them, or am I to remain here in this place? The right path before Thee prosper it in the hands of Thy servant… (Jubilees 12:21)*

The answer is not a map. It is *"Get thee up from thy country."* His father blesses him and stays behind: *"if thou seest a land pleasant to thy eyes to dwell in, then arise and take me to thee"* (12:30). Terah wants to see the land first. Abram has to go first.

Most of us know a Haran: somewhere we set out toward what God put in front of us — a calling, a reconciliation, a change — and stopped. Some stops are faithful waiting, like that night of prayer. Some are only comfortable. And some are love. The rabbis had God tell Abram, *"I exempt you from honoring your father and mother, but I do not exempt anyone else"* (Genesis Rabbah 39:7): staying beside someone who needs you is not Haran. Genesis only tells us where Terah's road ended: *"he died in Haran"* (11:32).

> **Talk about it.** Where is your Haran? Faithful waiting, or only comfortable — and what keeps you there?

2. "The land that I will show you" (12:1–5)

God names exactly what Abram must leave, and nothing about where he is going. The verb is ***ʾarʾekkā***, "I will make you see" — future tense. Why not say where? Rabbi Yoḥanan asked:

> *Why did he not reveal it [his destination] to him? It was to make it more endearing to him, and to give him a reward for each and every stride. (Genesis Rabbah 39:9)*

And in the same passage Rav Huna, quoting an older teacher:

> *The Holy One blessed be He withholds [information at first] and keeps the eyes of the righteous directed toward Him, and only then does he reveal to them the particulars of the matter. (Genesis Rabbah 39:9)*

The Hebrew says God *holds their eyes in suspense* — waiting, and looking up. Rav Huna's next example is the only other place in the Bible that says ***lek-lәḵā***, "Go": Abraham sent to Moriah, *"on one of the mountains which I will indicate to you"* (22:2). Hebrews keeps the order — the call, the obedience, then the not knowing: *"By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called… and he went out without understanding where he was going"* (11:8).

Not knowing is not having nothing. Abram had a word from God, a direction (Canaan), and people beside him: Sarai, his nephew Lot, and *"the people they had acquired in Haran,"* literally *"the souls they had made"* — household servants, Rashi says, though the midrash heard converts: *"Abraham converted the men and Sarah converted the women"* (Genesis Rabbah 39:14). Most of them walked this road because someone else had heard the word. *"So Abram left, just as the LORD had told him to do"* (12:4). He is seventy-five, and he does not say a word.

Hear 12:5 against 11:31 — in Hebrew, nearly word for word until the ending:

Terah (11:31)	**Abram (12:5)**
Terah took… they set out… *to go to the land of Canaan,*	*Abram took…* they set out *to go to the land of Canaan,*
and they came as far as Haran — and settled there.	*and they came* to the land of Canaan.

Sometimes God shows the way first: in the wilderness, Israel moved only when the cloud moved (Numbers 9:17–18). Sometimes he gives the next step and not the road. For us the word is seldom a voice; more often it is something Scripture already makes plain — forgive, be reconciled, serve — while what comes of it stays hidden.

> **Talk about it.** Have you ever had to start before you could see where it led? What did you learn on the road that you could not have learned before you set out?

3. "The LORD appeared" (12:6–7)

Abram walks on *"as far as the oak tree of Moreh at Shechem. (At that time the Canaanites were in the land.)"*

Moreh means "teacher," or "one who points the way" — from the same root as *Torah*. Many scholars think the great tree was a Canaanite holy place where people came for answers. And the land God promised to show him is already someone's home. (The midrash is generous: *"until then, they still had a right to the land,"* Genesis Rabbah 39:15.)

Then: *"The LORD appeared to Abram."* In Hebrew, ***wayyērāʾ*** — the same verb as *I will show you*. *"I will make you see"* becomes *"he let himself be seen."* It is the first time Genesis says God *appeared* to anyone, and Genesis saves it for the end of the road: more than four hundred miles after Haran. Ramban, the medieval commentator, pictured Abram crossing the land afraid, no land yet shown, until at Shechem *"G-d appeared to him and gave him the land, and as a result his fear departed from him… and then he built an altar to G-d in order to worship Him openly."*

What is Abram shown? Not a map. A promise: *"To your descendants I will give this land"* — said to a seventy-five-year-old, and to Sarai, who has no child (11:30) and has walked every mile without a word from God of her own. The showing does not make the hard things go away; it names the impossible thing and promises it anyway. Abram himself, Stephen says, was given *"not even a foot of ground"* (Acts 7:5). But every stride was counted.

4. An altar, a tent, and the road (12:7–9)

Abram answers with an altar *"to the LORD, who had appeared to him"* — the first since Noah's. He moves on, pitches his tent between Bethel and Ai, builds a second altar, and *"worshiped the LORD"* — literally, he *called on the name of the LORD* (4:26). Babel baked bricks for a name; Abram piles stones for God's name, and lives in a tent. And the passage ends: *"Abram continually journeyed by stages down to the Negev"* — ***hālôḵ wənāsôaʿ***, "going on and pulling up stakes." No *settled there*. He is still walking.

The first hearers knew every place he stopped. Jacob would build an altar at Shechem (33:20) and dream at Bethel (28:19); Joshua would fight at Ai and renew the covenant at Shechem (Joshua 8; 24). Rashi passes on the midrash that Abram was praying ahead for his children, and for their failures: at Shechem for Jacob's sons, *"when they would come to fight against Shechem,"* at Ai for the sin of Achan. The rabbis' saying, which Ramban made a rule for all the stories of the fathers: *"Whatever has happened to the patriarchs is a sign to the children."* And to the exiles in Babylon, *"Ur of the Chaldeans"* was no far-off name: the Chaldeans had carried them there, and Abram's road was their road home. The prophet told them: *"Look at Abraham, your father… When I summoned him, he was a lone individual, but I blessed him and gave him numerous descendants"* (Isaiah 51:2).

We walk ahead of other people too — children, grandchildren, the people beside us today. The altars we build along the road, the places where we stop and call on God's name, are where they will find him after us.

Next week

Famine (12:10). Abram goes down to Egypt — no altar this time — and his first recorded words are a scheme to save his own skin. Walking before you can see is one thing. Running on fear, with a scheme, is another.

So what?

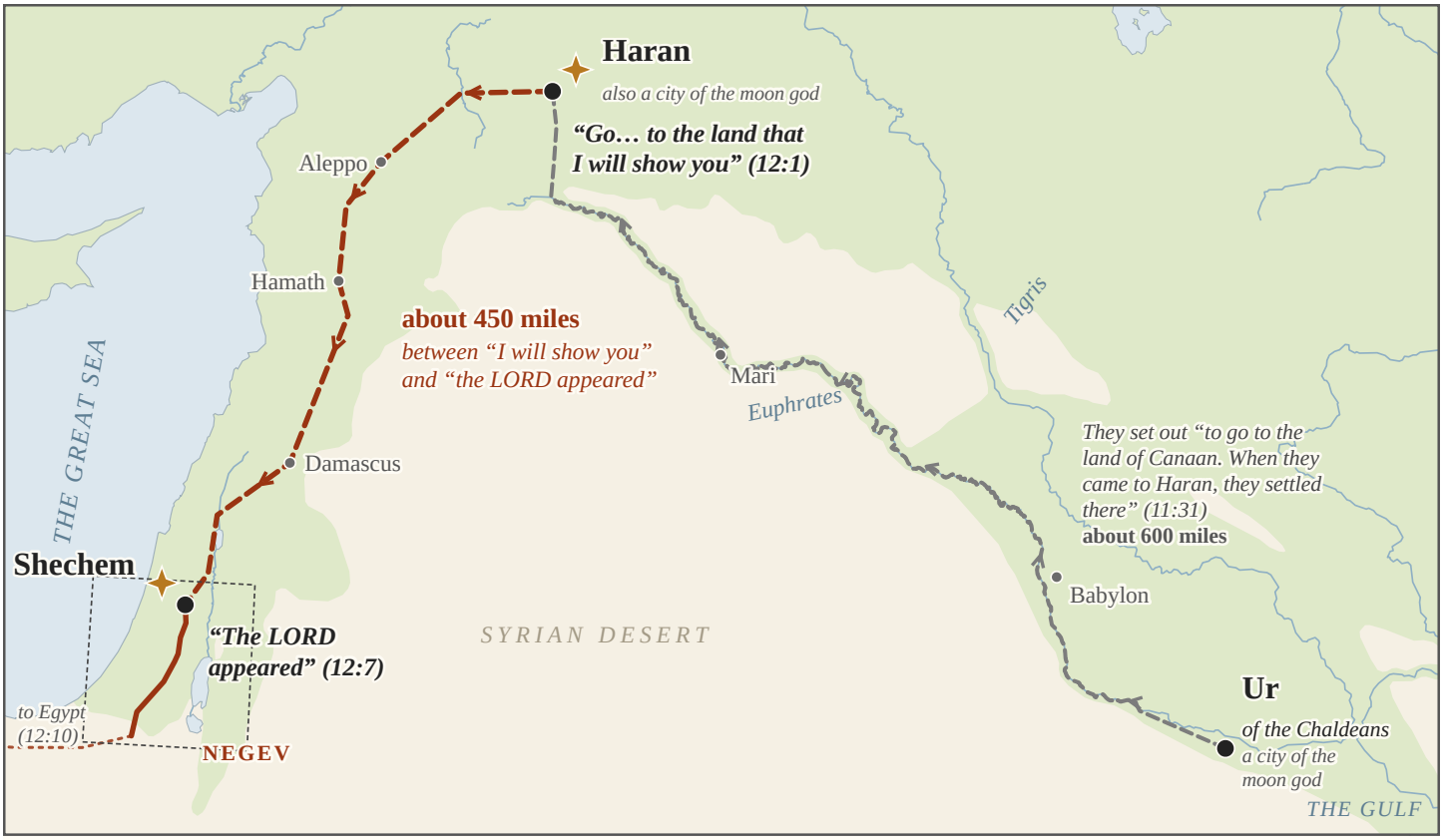
1. God's word finds people where they have stopped. It came to Abram in Haran.

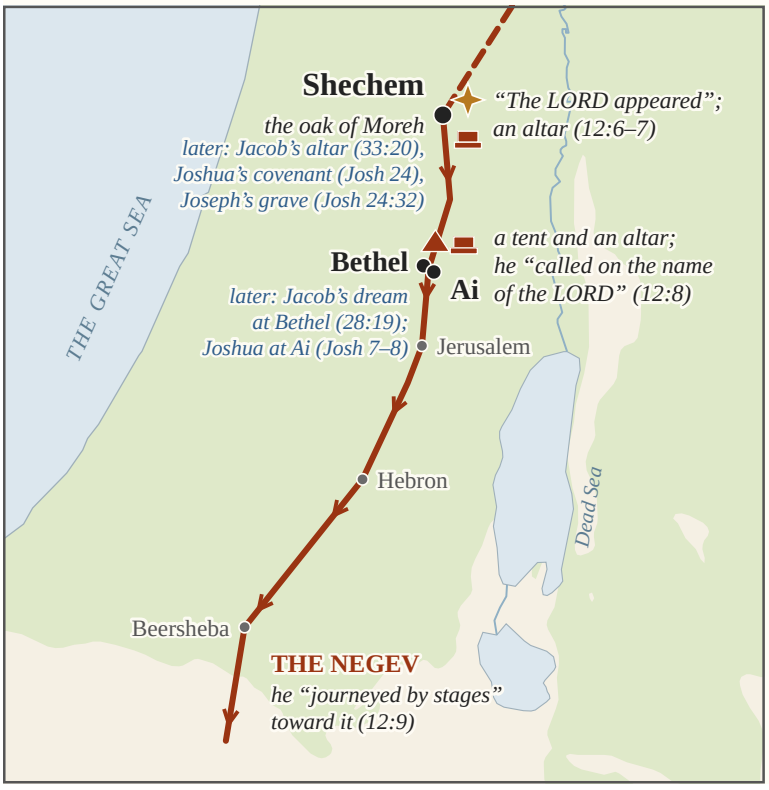
2. The next step comes before the map. The land was hidden to make it dear, to count every stride, and to keep Abram looking up. *"Your word is a lamp to walk by"* (Psalm 119:105) — a lamp, not a floodlight.

3. The seeing comes on the road — for Abram, as a promise, not a plan. At Shechem God showed him a gift he would not hold himself.

4. Walk with an altar and a tent. Worship where you stop; hold the camp lightly. Someone walks behind you, and someone already lives where you are going: the *Go* was *"so that all the families of the earth may receive blessing"* (12:3).

> **Talk about it — to close.** What step in front of you are you waiting to see past? Is the word already plain? What would it look like to take the step this week — and where will you build your altar?





Abram's road

Genesis 11:31–12:9

- Terah's family, Ur to Haran (11:31)
- Abram, Haran to Shechem (12:4–6)
- Abram in the land (12:6–9)
- God speaks (12:1, 7)
- an altar (12:7, 8)
- a tent (12:8)
- *Aa* later on the same ground
- fertile land, watered by rain or river

On foot, roughly

Ur to Haran	about 600 miles
Haran to Shechem	about 450 miles
Shechem to Bethel and Ai	about 20 miles
Bethel to Beersheba	about 55 miles

Genesis names no stop between Haran and Shechem; the dashed road follows the main route. Places: Pleiades (CC BY); climate zones: Beck et al. 2023 (CC BY 4.0); coastlines and rivers are modern.

Abram's road. *Above:* with his father from Ur up the Euphrates to Haran (11:31), then on his own south to Shechem (12:4–6). The stars mark where God speaks: *"I will show you"* at Haran, *"the LORD appeared"* at Shechem. Genesis does not say which road Abram took from Haran; this one follows the main road through Aleppo and Damascus. *Below:* the land, 12:6–9 — two altars, a tent, and the road on toward the Negev; in blue, what later happened at the same places. Green is land watered by rain or river. Sources for every place on Abram's road on the ground.